McNamara explained that there was a submarine close to each ship, which were estimated to be some twenty to thirty miles from where the interception would take place, 'hence, it's a very dangerous situation,' the Defense Secretary warned.[86] He explained that ASW helicopters would try to divert the submarines away from the intercept point.

Robert Kennedy recounts, 'these few minutes were the time of greatest concern for the President … His hand went up to his face and covered his mouth. He opened and closed his fist. His face seemed drawn, his eyes pained, almost gray. We just stared at each other across the table.'[87] Kennedy wanted to know at what point the submarine would be attacked if it did not comply with the warning. 'I think we ought to wait on that today. We don't want to have the first thing we attack as a Soviet submarine. I'd much rather have a merchant ship.'[88]

McNamara, however, was very clear: 'I think it would be extremely dangerous, Mister President, to try to defer an attack on this submarine in the situation we're in. We could easily lose an American ship by that means.'[89] So, whatever McNamara said to Admiral Anderson on Tuesday evening, on Wednesday morning he was fully appreciative of the potential imperative of sinking Soviet submarines in the imposition of the blockade. The blockade may have been a means of communicating with Khrushchev, but it was also a blockade. It meant, if need be, boarding, attacking, or even sinking, Soviet ships. One lesson that Kennedy might have learned from the disastrous restrictions on the scope and focus of the attacks on Castro's air force in April 1961 was that political interference in military operations could be highly dangerous. As Joseph Bouchard concludes, while Kennedy and McNamara were anxious to ensure political control, they were sympathetic to the military's concern with protecting their men. As Bouchard observes, the President and his Defense Secretary signed off on quarantine rules of engagement that 'specifically authorized use of force against submarines in self-defence or anticipatory self-defence'.[90]

When asked by the President what would happen if the submarine sank a US destroyer, McNamara explained the Submarine Surfacing and Identification Procedures (SSIP). The SSIP entailed using first sonar, and then if that did not work, explosive charges to signal the submarines they